

The Perito Moreno Glacier

An impressive Patagonian glacier that can be seen discharging huge quantities of ice into an Argentinian lake



The Perito Moreno is an outlet glacier from the Southern Patagonian Icefield (see p.101), descending to the east of the icefield, where it discharges icebergs into Argentina's largest lake, Lago Argentino. The glacier is about 15 miles (24 km) long, has an area of about 80 square miles (200 square km), and terminates in a vast wall of ice that is some 3 miles (5 km) wide. Unlike most of the world's glaciers, the Perito Moreno is not retreating, although glaciologists are uncertain why that is.

Calving face

Situated in Los Glaciares National Park, the glacier is one of Patagonia's most visited sites. It is possible to go on a guided trek over the glacier's surface. Many sightseers enjoy witnessing huge shards of ice falling off the glacier's calving face. The best time to view this is in the afternoon when, due to the Sun's warmth, disintegration events occur about every half an hour.

THE BRAZO RICO ICE DAM

The glacier periodically advances and blocks off Brazo Rico, an arm of Lago Argentino. An ice dam forms, and Brazo Rico may then rise as much as 200 ft (60 m) before its waters break through the dam, discharging about a billion tons of water in 24 hours.



The Perito Moreno's **iceberg-calving** wall of ice towers **240 ft (74 m)** above Lago Argentino

▷ CLOSING IN

Here, the glacier is forming a dam between Brazo Rico (at the bottom) and Lago Argentino (at the top). Icebergs can be seen calving into Brazo Rico.

◁ SAILING BY

Massive blocks and pinnacles of ice slowly move downhill. In the foreground are boulders and other rock debris deposited at the glacier's side.



△ CRASHING DOWN

The ice dam eventually breaks down as water pressure forces a tunnel through it. Soon afterward, the ice bridge over the tunnel dramatically collapses.